

▶ AN OUTLIER

Baseball thrives on specialisation. Pitchers rarely hit, and hitters almost never pitch. Then came Shohei Ohtani.

The Japanese superstar has redefined what a two-way player can be, influencing games with both bat and ball. On October 17, playing for the Los Angeles Dodgers, Ohtani delivered a performance that stretched the limits of precedent.

In Game 4 of the National League Championship Series against the Milwaukee Brewers, he smashed three home runs in the first, fourth and seventh innings, with one clearing the stadium entirely. He became the first pitcher ever to hit three home runs in a postseason game.

As if that were not enough, Ohtani also pitched six scoreless innings, striking out 10 batters.

Before that night, 503 players in professional baseball had hit three home runs in a game, and 1,550 had recorded double-digit strikeouts. Those feats had never intersected. Until Ohtani.

The display was swiftly hailed as one of the greatest individual performances in the sport's history. Dodgers manager Dave Roberts did not hedge.

"That was probably the greatest postseason performance of all time," Roberts said. "There's a reason he's the greatest player on the planet."



▶ BY THE BAREST OF MARGINS

Lando Norris was crowned the 2025 Formula One world champion during the final weekend of the season at the Yas Marina Circuit in Abu Dhabi.

The British driver successfully defended his 12-point lead over closest challengers Max

Verstappen and Oscar Piastri, clinching his maiden drivers' title by two points. Norris, who needed a podium finish to secure the championship, started second on the grid behind defending champion Verstappen.

His McLaren teammate Piastri overtook him early, leaving Norris to defend third place amid pressure from faster cars behind. While he fended off several challenges, his most demanding phase came after his pit stop, when he rejoined the race behind midfield runners on alternate strategies.

The 26-year-old responded with composure and precision, picking off rivals one by one and

denying them any chance to counterattack. At one stage, he executed two overtakes in a single corner before encountering his stiffest resistance in Yuki Tsunoda, Verstappen's Red Bull teammate.

Tasked with making Norris' progress as difficult as possible, Tsunoda drove aggressively, pushing track limits in a tense battle. Both drivers were investigated by the stewards, who ultimately ruled Tsunoda at fault, sparing Norris any penalty.

When the chequered flag fell, Norris crossed the line in third place to seal the championship and etch his name into the sport's history as Formula One's 35th world champion. Verstappen won the race, with Piastri finishing second.

